

world GDP. There was a large commercialised sector with a highly sophisticated market and credit structure. It was manned by a skillful, and in many instances, very wealthy commercial class. Methods of production and of industrial and commercial organisation could stand comparison with those in vogue in any part of the world. India, by then, also developed an indigenous banking system. Its bills of exchange were honoured in all the major cities of Asia.

These facts have not been conjured in the mind of someone obsessed with India's glorious past. These are recorded by respected global economy historian Prof. Angus Maddison. He has painstakingly constructed the structure of world income over the past three centuries. By the beginning of the 19th century, however, India's share of the world economy began to decline—gradually at first and then more steeply. Its share of the global economy reached a low point of around 4 per cent in the second half of the 20th century. Then we lost the edge, so did China. Once again, in our present time the wheels of history are turning. In the next 25 years, two-thirds of world's GDP will come from emerging Asia. I believe the 21st century is poised to become an India century. The favourable combination of factors is before the whole world. India is the fastest growing free market democracy. All of you are aware of these facts which confirm the prognosis that India is well on its way to becoming a major economic power. Let me, however, put in a caveat. Nothing in the life of a nation or a company is inevitable. And even when opportunities knock at the door, the outcome will depend on whether we seize them effectively and in time. India is, once again, at such a crossroad in her chequered history.

The outcome will depend on one crucial factor: leadership. Therefore, we need to redefine the meaning of leader-

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With session chairperson Adil Zainulbhai

important problem? And are we engaged in solving it? If the answer is in the positive, they would have qualified to play a global role. For centuries, the world's standards were set in its most advanced nations. The poorer emulated and imitated. Now, it is likely to be the other way. It is inevitable that innovation's centre of gravity will ultimately shift. So far, nations rich in income set the rules of global investment and trade. From now on, nations rich in natural resources, capital and knowledge will set these rules. So far, economic growth catered to just 15 per cent of the global population at the top of the income pyramid. From now on, economic growth will cater to 85 per cent of the global population at the bottom of the income pyramid.

And on all these parameters, India has a huge advantage. All that we need is to leverage these advantages. But business with global ambitions cannot afford to be concerned only about financial returns. To aspire for global leadership is a legitimate business ambition. But there must be a global purpose. A dream to transform some aspect of the world we have inherited. Passion to bring hope to the lives of those whom prosperity has passed by. The edifice of global business leadership should be built on an ennobling vision. And, when you reach there, thank God that He chose you to bring joy to the lives of millions of men, women and children.

DISCUSSION

Q. Everybody who works with Reliance from the top to the bottom seems to speak in one voice 'Reliance ethos are very strong'. How do you get everybody to march on the same tune?

Ambani: Well, I believe that one needs to articulate the goal very clearly. We have a saying at Reliance that if you focus on the goal, you overcome all obstacles. If you focus on obstacles, you will never reach your goal. So that is one aspect, one methodology that we all believe in and the other most impor-

tant aspect is that the entire team from the top to the bottom, in whatever initiatives you are executing, works with passion and is very loyal to the end cause. And if you could articulate the end game in a business in terms of saying that if we are developing an oil and gas business—finding gas in India and taking it to millions of households is really going to change the lives of millions of people.

Q. How is it that the same Indian when he goes to private sector does wonders but when he is

in the government he does not deliver. How can we correct this?

Ambani: We really need to get rid of our colonial mindset and build a partnership. The most important thing is that the governments have to be the facilitators and create a spirit of trust. If the Indian society is going to be a winning society, all of us have to be proud Indians, be proud of all components and constituents of our business and I think we are getting there.

Q. What do politicians and business leaders need to do to

make relationships more profitable so that we become leaders?

Ambani: My simple answer is build trust and respect each other.

Q. What's the biggest challenge that we will face in the 21st century?

Ambani: The biggest thing that I worry about is talent and education. I worry about skills level that we have. How do we continuously rejuvenate ourselves?

Full speech and debate at:

<http://www.indiatodayconclave.com>